These days the use of drugs, alcohol and tobacco has been increasing especially among teenagers and adolescents for adventure, excitement, curiosity and experimentation.

Let's analyse some of the consequences of sexual and childhood abuse, its prevention and protection.

21.1.1 Child Abuse

Child abuse constitutes all forms of physical or emotional ill treatment, sexual abuse, **exploitation** resulting in child's ill health, survival and development. **Physical abuse** of a child is defined as those acts that cause physical harm such as threatening, beating, kicking and hitting the child.

21.1.2 Sexual Abuse

Sexual harassment is a form of power and dominance of one person over another, which can result in harmful consequence to the victim. It refers to inappropriate or forced sexual contact. Adolescent girls and women encounter sexual harassment in different forms. Sexual abuse is more common at work places. Verbal remarks, comments, gestures and looks are the most common forms of abuse. This results in psychological distress, physical illness and eating disorders in the affected individuals.

More to Know

The Ministry of Women and Child Development championed the introduction of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012. People who traffic children for sexual purposes are also punishable under the provisions relating to the Act.



Objectives of the POCSO Act, 2012

- To protect children from the offences of
  - Sexual assault
  - Sexual harassment
  - Pornography
- To establish Special Courts for speedy trial of such offences.

21.1.3 Child Sexual Abuse

Children are considered soft targets for sexual abuse because they may not realize that they are being abused. Commonly, abusers are persons well known to the child, may even be living in the same locality. Abusers also bribe (use chocolates and toys) to lure children and take advantage of the child's innocence.

Sexually abused children show symptoms of genital injury, abdominal pain, frequent urinary infection and behavioural problems.

21.1.4 Approaches for Protection of an Abused Child

Measures adopted for monitoring and assessment of abused child who have undergone signs and symptoms of distress are:

Child Helpline: The Child Helpline provides a social worker who can assist the child by providing food, shelter and protection.

Counselling the child: Psychologists and social workers should provide guidance, counselling and continous support to a victimized child.

Family support: The victimized child should be supported by the family members. They should be provided with proper care and attention to overcome their sufferings.

Medical care: A child victim of sexual offences should receive medical care and treatment from health care professionals to overcome mental stress and depression.

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